



“Half boat, half aeroplane, taking off in a tumult of spray – the flying boat was a journey of a lifetime.”

GRAHAM COSTER

FROM *CORSAIRVILLE: THE LOST DOMAIN OF THE FLYING BOAT*



SUPERB SUNDERLAND

The Short Sunderland – shown here with beaching gear, used after removing the craft from the water – was a military version of the Empire-class flying boats used by Britain's Imperial Airways. First used by the RAF in 1938, the Sunderland gave outstanding service in WWII.

FLYING BOATS AND AIRSHIPS

AS THE ERA OF LONG-DISTANCE PASSENGER AIR TRAVEL TOOK SHAPE, AIRSHIPS AND FLYING BOATS COMPETED FOR TRANSOCEANIC ROUTES

IN OCTOBER 1928, at a time when every shaky, perilous crossing of the Atlantic by airplane was still headline news, the German airship *Graf Zeppelin* carried a score of passengers on a nonstop flight from the Alps to Lakehurst, New Jersey. They traveled in style, with private cabins, well-appointed bathrooms, gourmet food, and a carpeted dining room from which they enjoyed the breathtaking views. This was a real ship of the air, designed to compete with the Blue Riband liners of the ocean below. Its proponents believed fervently that the *Graf Zeppelin* represented the future of long-distance passenger air travel.

The performance of zeppelins during World War I, although militarily ineffectual, had made German airship technology an object of fear and envy for the country's enemies. At the end of the war, the victors were determined to procure zeppelins for themselves and deny them to the Germans. In 1919 a promising attempt to resurrect DELAG, the company that had operated an airship passenger service in Germany before the war, was nipped in the bud when its two zeppelins were seized as reparations. Further airship production was banned and the Zeppelin factory in Friedrichshafen was earmarked for destruction. Now under the dominant influence of wartime airship commander Hugo Eckener, the Zeppelin company won a stay of execution by offering to build an airship for the US Navy. Called the USS *Los Angeles*, it took until 1924 to produce, by which time wartime animosities were fading and Zeppelin won a reprieve.



AERIAL AIRCRAFT CARRIER

Shown emerging from the clouds, the short-lived US Navy USS Akron (ZR-4) was a product of the Goodyear-Zeppelin factory and one of the world's strangest aircraft – an aerial aircraft carrier.

The Zeppelin company also sought survival through an alliance with the United States. In 1923, Goodyear formed a joint corporation with Zeppelin, obtaining rights to its patents.

The United States had one major advantage over Germany – access to helium. During the war this had been identified as a suitable lifting gas because, unlike the hydrogen used in German airships, it was

not flammable. Almost all the world's supply of this rare gas came from a single small area of Texas.

The sole customer for American airships was the US Navy, but its experience with helium-filled airships suggested that they were too fragile for long-term regular use. The *Shenandoah*, a US-built version of a wartime zeppelin, was torn in half when caught in a violent storm in Ohio in 1925; the *Akron*, the first product of the Goodyear-Zeppelin factory, went down in the ocean off New Jersey in 1933; its sister airship, the *Macon*, met the same fate in 1935. Only the *Los Angeles* fulfilled its service life without disaster.

Imperial airships

The British experience of rigid airships was even less encouraging. The postwar period started promisingly with an impressive flight by the R 34, a British copy of the German L 33 that had been shot down over England during the war. With 31 people, including a stowaway, on board, the R 34 flew nonstop from Scotland to Mineola, New York, in July 1919, in four and a half days and then flew back. But attempts to build on this success led to disaster. In 1921 the British-built R 38 snapped in two under the stress of tight maneuvers during flight trials over the port city of Hull. Both halves caught fire and exploded, killing 44 of the crew. Nevertheless, Britain eventually pursued the idea